

6.3.10 I Love Gmail; Can I Use It At Work?

The idea is, some offices and colleges block Webmail sites. You'll find out soon enough. Even otherwise, it doesn't "look good" if you're often seen with a Gmail window open (and since Gmail integrates a chat facility, you might be tempted to visit www.gmail.com quite often). But remember that Gmail (for one) offers you the facility of downloading your mail via POP3 and/or IMAP to your mail program: in Gmail, just click on Settings, then go to the "Forwarding and POP3/IMAP" tab.

The choice is getting a bit hazy. For one, connection speeds are improving, so much of the virtue of IMAP is getting eroded. Second, many Webmail sites (notably the new Beta of Yahoo! Mail) are giving you the look and feel of a mail program. Third, you're more likely than ever to see Webmail interfaces for, say, your office mail, or your domain mail. And then, you have the fact that, for example, Gmail as mentioned above, gives you free POP3 and IMAP mail (God alone knows why they do it; you don't see any Google ads in your mail program when you use POP3 or IMAP for your Gmail).

In any case, that's 10 questions answered; you decide... and if you decide that you need a mail program (or an e-mail client, if you will), here are a few that deserve mention.

6.4 Outlook Express (OE)

OE must be mentioned because it's there on all Windows computers up until XP. Several people advocate dumping OE, primarily because of security concerns; some have reported data loss when OE "compacts" messages automatically. Then, there are some weird bugs that Microsoft refuses to iron out: for example, when a message is open in its own window, you can delete it from the main OE window... and then when you click Delete on the *message* window, the zombie of a thing just says "The message could not be deleted." Other irritants include, but are not limited to, composition of messages in HTML not behaving as it should, and weird behaviour upon pasting of text into mail composition windows.